

Blue bird-of-paradise

To show off to a female, the male blue bird-of-paradise hangs upside down from a branch and spreads out his lacy flank plumes in a shimmering fan. His long tail streamers form arches over his body while he shivers and sways to and fro. At the same time, he makes a strange, grating call, which sounds like an electric drill. Each male displays alone in special dance trees. The females choose to mate with the male that makes the best display.

Blue bird-of-paradise
(*Paradisornis rudolphi*)
Length: 2 ft 3 in (70 cm)

Male displaying to a female.

Male blue bird-of-paradise when not displaying.

The male holds his tail up during courtship displays.

King bird-of-paradise
(*Cicinnurus regius*)
Length: 1 ft (31 cm)
Male's tail: 5½ in (14 cm)

King bird-of-paradise

The bright red feathers of the male king bird-of-paradise contrast with the dull brown of the female. The female's colors help camouflage her while she cares for the eggs and chicks. She collects all the food she needs for herself and her chicks in the rainforest, leaving the male free for his stunning courtship displays.

Feet have a strong, viselike grip on branches.

Male

Female

Eclectus parrot
(*Eclectus roratus*)
Length: 1 ft 6 in (45 cm)

Red-breasted pygmy-parrot

This parrot lives only on New Guinea and some of the nearby islands, where there are no woodpeckers. As it clings to tree trunks, this parrot uses its spiny tail feathers for support—just like a woodpecker. It feeds on lichens and fungi and may also eat other plants and insects.

Red-breasted pygmy-parrot
(*Micrositta bruijnii*)
Length: 3½ in (9 cm)

Stiff tail used as a prop.



A palm cockatoo feasts on fruit from the nonda plum tree. This species is Australia's biggest parrot.

